

The fourth and final money leak is bigger than the previous three combined. In recent years, online dating has experienced a meteoric surge in popularity. An estimated 30 to 40 million North Americans now use online dating sites, with more than 1,500 different websites catering to the lonely masses. The industry is worth over \$1.5 billion—not at all surprising when you consider that a quarter of all Canadians have tried Internet dating. And those are just the ones being honest about it.

I'm not going to weigh in on the efficacy of online dating or how likely you are to find lasting love with the click of a mouse. That's not my department. The question I want you to ask yourself is: How much of that \$1.5 billion is coming out of *your* pocket? And are you getting your money's worth? First, there are the obvious price tags. Average membership on an Internet dating site ranges from \$30 to \$60 a month—double that at the more “exclusive” sites. Also, keep in mind that online dating enables a higher quantity of dates because of the larger pool of potential partners. I've known people with active profiles on multiple websites who go out with a different person every night of the week, and sometimes more than once a day. The first three money leaks—transportation, fancy dinners, expensive clothes—are still sucking money away, only now it's on a much bigger scale. Spend \$300 eight or nine times a week and the costs are staggering. One month will put a \$10,800 dent in your wallet—or more likely, your credit card. And more often than not, all of that cash spent doesn't result in any kind of long-lasting relationship; rather, it results in less cash in the wallet and more heartbreak and loneliness.

Then there are the hidden costs. With the rise of online dating has come a parallel rise in online dating scams. Take Teresa, a woman who truly believed she had met her soulmate. Philip claimed to be a humanitarian aid worker currently deployed overseas. They exchanged dozens of emails, and Philip sent Teresa pictures of himself and his young daughter. After several months, the daughter purportedly got sick. Soon Philip was asking Teresa for money, and against her better judgment, she was sending it. By the time she figured out what was going on, she had sent him over \$40,000.